

This DVD will self-destruct in 5 seconds...

Flexplay and Buena Vista Home Entertainment have unveiled a new technology that makes DVDs unreadable after 48 hours. Known as an EZ-D, once it is removed from the packaging, its exposure to oxygen interacts with the disc's coating to make it inoperable, roughly two days later. This is all part of a new offer from Buena Vista Home Entertainment's DVD rental program to be launched this



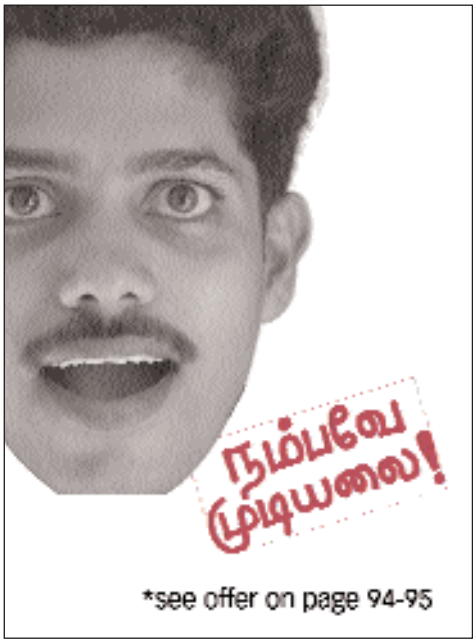
August. The Flexplay system, which uses materials from GE's plastics division, can play on any system. The DVD with a limited shelf life isn't new. Circuit City tried to roll out the first timed DivX disc format and failed. Robert Moore, president of 321 Studio, said, "This move to create self-destructing DVDs by Buena Vista Entertainment

implies that consumers are dishonest in their use of technology". The creation of these non-recyclable, one-use products will create unnecessary landfill waste, or release harmful toxins into the air when such trash is incinerated. Environmental experts agree that self-destructing DVDs are extremely harmful to the environment. In addition, consumers are displeased with the negative environmental impact of these products. Consumers that rent DVDs would rather prefer to either to purchase or rent traditional DVDs.

PS2...oops, I mean a Supercomputer...

Scientists at the National Center for Supercomputing Applications at the University of Illinois's Urbana-Champaign campus have developed a supercomputer by wiring 70 PlayStations together. The consoles were stripped off their plastic casing and networked together using a high-speed HP network switch. The project is powered by the open source Linux operating system, and otherwise, uses all standard components. Its computing power comes from a highly tuned custom designed silicon chip, called the Emotion Engine. This superchip is capable of churning out an amazing 6.5 billion mathematical operations a second, and was originally intended to quickly ren-

der and transform pixels on a television screen to produce life-like graphics. Though there is a memory bandwidth limitation when using such consoles, scientists claim that the cluster can solve problems in a narrow range of scientific applications. They are currently writing specially tuned applications to run on the system to benchmark it. The centre chose the PlayStation 2, because unlike the Xbox, Sony sells a special Linux module and a high-speed network connection and a disk drive. With each console costing less than \$200, this could mean a whole new shift towards building supercomputers with low-cost off the shelf technology.



snapshot

The typical gamer is a **19-to-34-year old male**, playing **video or PC games** for **9 or more years**, and averages **10+ hours** of playing time per week

Source: netcraft, 2002

You've got Spam!

According to reports, two-thirds of mobile phone owners have been victimised by spam. The Independent Committee for the Supervision of Standards of Telephone Information Services (ICSTIS) has suggested that SMS spam is a greater violation of one's privacy, and the limited phone capacity for SMS storage may soon not be enough—possibly



blocking legitimate and important SMS messages. Governments and corporations are beginning to take notice. Microsoft has started a project called Penny Black—named after the first British postal stamp in the 1830's—to find a way to make spammers pay per e-mail they send. The Australian government

has announced that mobile service providers carrying unsolicited bulk messages could be fined up to 10 million Australian dollars. It is obvious that SMS spam will never be as big a problem as junk e-mail, as the costs of sending bulk SMS messages are much higher. Most people are still learning to live with junk e-mails, and to have the privacy of our mobile phones invaded might just be the last straw.

■ Microsoft has dropped the prices of Office XP worldwide and announced a special edition for Thai customers of Windows XP and Office XP for just \$38.50.